

The 1848 Revolutions

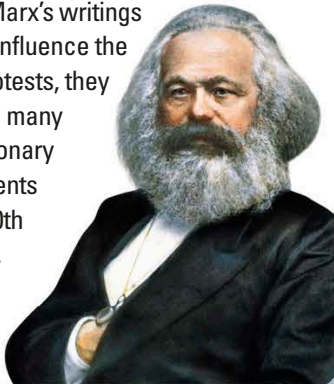
In the early months of 1848, a wave of revolutions spread like wildfire across Europe. The first began in Sicily in January. In February, violent protests in France brought an end to the French monarchy. By March, revolutions had broken out in cities throughout present-day Germany and the Austrian Empire, including Hungary and parts of Italy.

One of the main causes of the unrest was a series of poor harvests in the mid-1840s, leading to widespread famine and hardship. In the industrial cities of Europe, unemployment and poverty increased, and the gap between the rich and the poor grew wider. At the same time, harsh governments refused to allow more people the right to vote.

In parts of the Austrian empire, such as Hungary and Italy, people sharing the same language and culture demanded the right to rule themselves. Shaken by the speed and violence of the protests, governments at first promised political change.

KARL MARX

German philosopher Karl Marx (1818–1883) published *The Communist Manifesto* with coauthor Friedrich Engels just before the events of 1848. The book predicted revolution in Europe as a result of the “class struggle” between the rich and poor. While Marx’s writings did not influence the 1848 protests, they inspired many revolutionary movements in the 20th century.



A parliament elected to unite Germany met for the first time in May, and in Denmark and the Netherlands greater democratic freedom was allowed. But by the end of the year, the revolutions had mostly been put down by military force, crushing all hopes of political reform for the immediate future.

▼ REVOLUTION IN PARIS

On February 23, soldiers in Paris opened fire on people protesting against the banning of political meetings in France. In the riots that followed, King Louis Philippe was forced to give up his throne and protesters declared the Second French Republic.



▼ FRANKFURT PARLIAMENT

Two months after the March revolutions, a parliament for all of Germany—then divided into 39 separate states—met in Frankfurt with plans to unify the country and give it a democratic constitution (set of laws) under the king of Prussia. However, their hopes ended when the king refused to cooperate.

